

Local Buy Nothing App/ Extension

Team Brainy Bunch

Project Overview/ Introduction

For our project this semester, we propose an app that gives neighbors a space to connect, share ideas, save money and reduce waste. Our app will be based on the ideas of a gifting economy. Imagine: Neighbors being able to share with each other clothes they no longer like, toys their kids have grown out of using, or extra food that ended up being not quite their taste, all for no cost.

What problem(s) our software hopes to solve

Many people have useful items that they no longer need but are still valuable to others, At the same time, many individuals and families need household goods, clothing, furniture, electronics, supplies, and other items but may not have the financial means to purchase them. Existing marketplaces are often focused on buying and selling rather than community sharing and also suffer with issues such as fake accounts, spam, favoritism, and disorganized communication.

Our Buy-Nothing App aims to create a dedicated platform for community-based donations and gifting. This app promotes sustainability by reducing waste, encourages community engagement and teamwork, and provides a fair and organized platform. By moving away from traditional social media platforms and into a tailored built platform, users can enjoy a safer and more efficient experience.

Who our app hopes to help

Our app hopes to help a local neighborhood buy nothing group that wants to operate on their own without outside interference. Our app will provide a dedicated space for giving away, requesting and exchanging items while reducing distractions. By focusing on local neighbors, the app will make it easier for the community members to connect, reduce waste, and support one another.

How will our software be unique from its competitors?

Our software will be its own app. It won't be on facebook or other social media platforms like our competitors. This will allow users to participate in their local Buy Nothing community without distractions, ads, or unrelated social media content. The app will focus solely on giving, receiving, and sharing items with neighbors, making it easier to connect with the local community and reduce waste. Users will have a simpler time and experience navigating our app rather than having to navigate a larger social media platform.

Can your app be generated simply by prompting an LLM/agent?

A basic version of a Buy Nothing app could be partially generated by an LLM, such as creating listings, writing item descriptions, or matching simple “gift” and “ask” posts. However, an LLM alone would not be able to handle the real-world structure, safety, and coordination required for a trusted local exchange system. Our app goes beyond what an LLM or prompt-based system can generate by using a database-backed system with verified users through questionnaires, human review, and admin blocking, requiring each post to include photos and structured data, using a fair request system with queues, random or selected choices, and timed decisions, and including real-time status updates like an “already gone” button, along with structured Gift/Ask/Random/Select options and a location-restricted community design, which together require persistent data, rule enforcement, and coordination that an LLM alone cannot handle.

Conclusion

By the end of the semester we hope to have created something that helps real people by dismantling a cost barrier and cultivating community engagement. Our alternative to Buy-Nothing groups on Facebook will aim to be more accessible, organized, and user-friendly than the current options available. We want to enable people to not only have neighbors, but community.